

Texas WIC Health and Human Services Commission

Effective: November 1, 2025

Policy No. BF 10.0

Issuance of Nipple Shields and Supplemental Nursing Systems

Purpose

To provide guidance on the issuance and follow-up of nipple shields and supplemental nursing systems (SNS).

Authority

7 CFR 246.14(c)(10), AC:34.0, WIC Breastfeeding Policy and Guidance

Policy

Once determined to be appropriate based on a breastfeeding assessment, breastfeeding aids such as nipple shields and supplemental nursing systems may be issued to WIC breastfeeding clients. Under the guidance of a lactation consultant or Designated Breastfeeding Expert, trained WIC staff must provide appropriate counseling, education and follow up as necessary for all issued breastfeeding aids, including those obtained outside of the clinic, to ensure support of each breastfeeding dyad.

Procedures

I. Nipple Shields

- A. Any staff who issue or counsel moms on nipple shields must first complete training on issuance of nipple shields according to [Policy TR:03.0](#).
- B. International Board Certified Lactation Consultants (IBCLCs) and the Local Agency (LA) Designated Breastfeeding Expert (DBE) are the most appropriate staff and should be utilized first, and when

Texas WIC Health and Human Services Commission

Effective: November 1, 2025

Policy No. BF 10.0

available, to counsel and issue nipple shields to mothers who need them. For definition of DBE, refer to [Policy GA:14.0](#).

- C. Non-IBCLC and non-DBE staff such as Certifying Authorities (CA) and Peer Counselors (PC) can issue and provide follow-up on nipple shields under the guidance of an IBCLC or DBE. Guidance can be provided by phone or video consult.
 - 1. If your LA IBCLC or DBE are not available to provide guidance, staff must call one of the lactation support center (LSC) IBCLCs prior to issuing the nipple shield, and document the contact details in the MIS. Contact details include name of LSC contacted, name of IBCLC who provided guidance and date of contact.
- D. Follow-up for all nipple shields, even those issued elsewhere, should occur within 7 calendar days or within 1-2 business days when deemed appropriate by the IBCLC or DBE. If the participant meets the criteria for high risk per [Policy CS:33](#), follow your LA's High Risk policy. Document follow-ups in the MIS.
- E. Designated staff trained to issue nipple shields must assist within their scope. Assess for:
 - 1. adequate weight gain for age. If this indicator is not met, determine a feeding plan and make appropriate referral(s).
 - 2. adequate diaper output. If this indicator is not met, determine a feeding plan and make appropriate referral(s).

Texas WIC Health and Human Services Commission

Effective: November 1, 2025

Policy No. BF 10.0

3. latch and shield use. When appropriate and possible, an observation of feeding with and without shield is recommended. Assess for:
 - a. audible swallows during the feed.
 - b. mom's comfort with and without shield.
 - c. effective fit and seal of the shield.
 - d. infant's ability to effectively latch and sustain latch through the feeding.

II. Supplemental Nursing System (SNS)

- A. At the LA's discretion, IBCLCs can counsel on and issue an SNS to mothers who need them.
- B. LAs that choose to offer an SNS must ensure current training of the issuing IBCLC.
- C. Training can be met through prior professional lactation skills training, or through a partnership with a senior IBCLC, local hospital or LSC.
 1. Training should be specific to the type of SNS offered by the LA.
- D. The LA IBCLC must provide follow-up by phone or video consult for all issued SNS within 24 hours (or on the next business day). Additional follow-up should continue at the discretion of the IBCLC. Document follow-up in the MIS.